

Linux is an Open Source Operating System (oh, and it's *free* too!)

What exactly do you mean by 'Open Source'?

- **Free of charge** – The open source GNU General Public License (GPL) that Linux uses means that you can obtain the software free of charge, and you can obtain the source code to the software and make changes to it if you want. You can then re-distribute it if you like, provided you supply the source code with your changes too.
- **Software stability** – Open standards provoke less buggy software because it is worked on by a global team of developers from many far reaching backgrounds.
- **Universal Compatibility** – Open standards also mean that compatibility across any other platform. For example, you can be sure that an open source OGG audio file will play on any OGG player in exactly the same way, because the open standard applies throughout.
- **No lock-in** – Open Source software means no vendor lock-in.
- **Open, trustworthy computing** – as the source code for all software is distributed for free, often with the applications you obtain. Imagine buying a car, and peering under the hood to find a black box that was completely unserviceable by you or your local mechanic. Imagine that it has to be updated/improved upon or fixed by a single garage who charge you extortionate amounts of money. Open source lets you in at the whole engine and allows anyone to work on improving the software.
- **Continual Popularity** – No chance of Linux as a whole going out of business, as it is not owned by any one company. Linux has been growing on the server and desktop market exponentially since the early 1990s.
- Did we mention that Open Source software is generally FREE in cost? 😊

This means that software can be of high quality for everyone, and money can be made out of support, distribution, training or working with open source software.

It's a revolutionary change in the way we perceive software and do business, however huge names like IBM, HP and Intel and even non IT firms such as Boeing, Glaxo Smithkline and thousands more are all using Open Source and Linux. Some of them are even putting work back into it.